



MEONCROSS SCHOOL | HISTORY DEPARTMENT

EDITION 2026.1

WAS THE 19TH CENTURY THE REAL TURNING POINT FOR MEDICINE IN BRITAIN?

*Paper 1: Medicine Through Time with the Western
Front - 18th & 19th C*

Scholar: _____

Class: _____

Edexcel Specification: c1700–c1900

- **1. Causes of disease:** From miasma to germ theory (Pasteur, Koch).
- **2. Prevention:** Jenner and the smallpox vaccine; public health reform.
- **3. Treatment:** Simpson and anaesthetics; Lister and antiseptics; Nightingale and nursing.
- **4. Case Study: Cholera and the Broad Street Pump (Snow, 1854).**

PROGRESS & ASSESSMENT TRACKER

TARGET GRADE: _____

Grade	9-1 GCSE Grading Scale		
Lesson / Assessment Title	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments
L1: KT3.1: What breakthrough discoveries changed our understanding of disease causes?			
L2: KT3.2: How did the Industrial Revolution transform prevention and treatment?			
L3: KT3.3: How significant were Edward Jenner and John Snow?			
Final Unit Grade:			

L1: KT3.1: What breakthrough discoveries changed our understanding of disease causes?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the difference between Spontaneous Generation and Germ Theory.
- ☐ Analyze the significance of Robert Koch's scientific methodology in microbiology.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

What did William Harvey discover about the human body?

What did Harvey prove wrong about Galen's theories of blood?

In what year did the Great Plague hit London?

What was 'transference'?

What was the Royal Society?

Who was Thomas Sydenham?

Who wrote 'On the Fabric of the Human Body' (1543)?

What invention helped spread new medical ideas during the Renaissance?

Why did the influence of the Church begin to decline in the Renaissance?

What did Vesalius prove about Galen's anatomical ideas?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Select *THREE* terms that share a close historical connection. Identify which *ONE* remaining term is the 'Odd One Out' in this lesson, and explain your historical reasoning:

Spontaneous Generation | Germ Theory | Bacteriology | Louis Pasteur | Robert Koch | Microscope

Q1. Explain how the Enlightenment helped create the conditions for Germ Theory.

Q2. Identify the scientist who published the Germ Theory in 1861.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

How did Pasteur's swan-neck flask experiment disprove the theory of spontaneous generation?

- ☐ A. It showed that liquids only decayed when exposed to airborne microbes, proving that microbes caused decay (not the other way around).
- ☐ B. It proved that microbes were killed by intense cold.
- ☐ C. It showed that diseases were spread by physical contact.
- ☐ D. It proved that microbes spontaneously appeared in a vacuum.

Q4. Describe what Spontaneous Generation was.

Q5. Explain how Robert Koch developed Pasteur's work.

Q6. Evaluate the significance of the Germ Theory on the history of medicine.

Pair & Share Activity

Q7. Prompt: Which was more significant in transforming British medicine: Louis Pasteur's theoretical proof of Germ Theory in 1861, or Robert Koch's practical scientific methods to identify specific disease-causing microbes in the 1870s and 1880s?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (e.g., Pasteur disproving spontaneous generation and providing the core principles, vs. Koch growing bacteria on agar jelly, staining them with dyes, and finding the TB and cholera microbes).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Pace of the Germ Theory Revolution

Historians actively debate how quickly Germ Theory transformed medical beliefs in Britain. While traditional narratives present Pasteur's 1861 publication as an overnight revolution that instantly swept away ancient superstitions, modern revisionist historians argue that the transition was incredibly slow and highly contested. They point out that Pasteur was a chemist, not a doctor, and his early work focused on wine and vinegar, leading prominent

British medical authorities like Dr. Henry Bastian to reject his ideas for decades. It was only after Robert Koch identified specific human pathogens (such as the tuberculosis microbe in 1882) and developed practical laboratory techniques that the wider medical community gradually accepted the link between germs and disease.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q8. Describe two features of Robert Koch's scientific methods for identifying bacteria.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q9. Explain why Robert Koch's scientific methods were significant in the development of Germ Theory.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

Q10. Explain one way in which ideas about the cause of illness in the period c1700-c1900 were different from ideas about the cause of illness in the period c1500-c1700.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q11. 'Louis Pasteur's publication of the Germ Theory was the biggest turning point in understanding the causes of disease.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

You may use the following in your answer:

- Spontaneous Generation
- Robert Koch

You must also use information of your own.

General Notes

L2: KT3.2: How did the Industrial Revolution transform prevention and treatment?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how hospital care and nursing standards were transformed c1700-c1900 under the influence of Florence Nightingale.
- ☐ Analyse how the breakthroughs of anaesthetics and antiseptics solved the critical surgical problems of pain and infection.
- ☐ Evaluate the role of government intervention in disease prevention through the 1875 Public Health Act.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

What was 'Spontaneous Generation'?

Who published the Germ Theory in 1861?

What did Robert Koch contribute to Germ Theory?

Why did many doctors reject Germ Theory at first?

What method did Robert Koch use to isolate and photograph bacteria?

What was 'transference'?

What did William Harvey discover about the human body?

Who was Thomas Sydenham?

What was the Royal Society?

Who wrote 'On the Fabric of the Human Body' (1543)?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

Laissez-faire | Compulsory | Aseptic surgery | Florence Nightingale | Joseph Lister | James Simpson

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q1)

How did Florence Nightingale's 'Notes on Nursing' (1859) help to improve the survival rates of patients in British hospitals?

- ☐ A. It taught nurses how to perform complex internal surgery.
- ☐ B. It established strict protocols for hygiene, ventilation, and cleanliness, drastically reducing infection rates.
- ☐ C. It proved that germs caused disease and taught nurses how to use carbolic acid.
- ☐ D. It taught nurses how to discover new antibiotics.

Q2. Identify the first effective anaesthetic discovered in 1847.

Q3. Describe the state of surgery before 1847.

Q4. Explain how Joseph Lister solved the problem of infection.

Q5. To what extent did Simpson's discovery of Chloroform immediately improve surgery?

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: Was the introduction of anaesthetics (James Simpson's Chloroform) or antiseptics (Joseph Lister's Carbolic Acid) a more significant turning point for patients undergoing surgery in the 19th century?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence (e.g., Chloroform solved patient pain but initially led to the 'Black Period' of higher death rates, while Carbolic Acid solved postoperative infection and dropped mortality rates from 46% to 15% but relied on Pasteur's Germ Theory).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the 'Black Period' of Surgery

Historians frequently debate the immediate consequences of James Simpson's 1847 discovery of chloroform. While popular history often celebrates chloroform as an overnight triumph that ended the horror of conscious amputations, medical historians point out that it ushered in a devastating 'Black Period' for British surgery. Because patients were unconscious and relaxed, surgeons attempted far deeper, more complex, and longer internal operations. However, because Lister's carbolic antiseptics were not introduced until 1865, surgeons still operated in filthy environments with unwashed hands and blood-stained coats. As a result, the 'Black Period' actually saw a dramatic increase in postoperative deaths from gangrene and infection, leading some historians to argue that the discovery of anaesthetics was a step backward for patient survival until antiseptics were finally developed.

Q7. Explain why Florence Nightingale's reforms were significant in improving hospital care.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

Q8. Explain one way in which surgical treatments in the period c1700-c1900 were different from surgical treatments in the medieval period (c1250-c1500).

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q9. 'The discovery of Carbolic Acid was the most significant turning point in surgery in the years c1700-c1900.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

[20 marks • 25 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- Joseph Lister
- Chloroform

You must also use information of your own.

General Notes

L3: KT3.3: How significant were Edward Jenner and John Snow?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the significance and limitations of Edward Jenner's development of the smallpox vaccine.
- ☐ Analyze how John Snow investigated the 1854 cholera epidemic and assess the significance of his findings.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

Who was Florence Nightingale?

What did Florence Nightingale believe caused disease?

Which anesthetic was discovered by James Simpson in 1847?

What was 'Spontaneous Generation'?

Who published the Germ Theory in 1861?

What did Robert Koch contribute to Germ Theory?

In what year did the Black Death arrive in England?

What did Vesalius prove about Galen's anatomical ideas?

Who introduced antiseptic surgery using carbolic acid in 1865?

What was the significance of the Public Health Act of 1875?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:

Inoculation Vaccination Spot Map Edward Jenner John Snow Broad Street Pump	
Power, Governance & Warfare	Economy, Trade & Society

Q1. Identify the disease Edward Jenner created a vaccine for.

Q2. Describe how Jenner proved his vaccine worked.

Q3. Explain the actions John Snow took during the 1854 Cholera outbreak.

Q4. Evaluate the significance of the 1875 Public Health Act.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q5)

How did John Snow prove that cholera was a waterborne disease in 1854, long before the discovery of germs?

☐ A. By looking at the cholera bacteria under a microscope.

- ☐ B. By mapping the deaths around the Broad Street pump, proving the victims shared a water source rather than breathing the same 'bad air'.
- ☐ C. By boiling all the water in London and watching the disease disappear.
- ☐ D. By injecting a cholera vaccine into local residents.

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: Whose breakthrough was a more significant turning point in the history of disease prevention: Edward Jenner's 1796 discovery of smallpox vaccination, or John Snow's 1854 discovery that cholera was water-borne?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (e.g., Jenner's vaccine being the first scientific prevention method that eventually wiped out a disease globally, versus Snow proving the link between physical sanitation and disease, which directly paved the way for Bazalgette's sewers and the 1875 Public Health Act).

Your Notes:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over the Catalysts for Victorian Public Health Reform

Historians debate the extent to which John Snow's 1854 Broad Street investigation was the primary driver behind the cleanup of Victorian London. Traditional narratives portray Snow as a lone hero whose pump-handle intervention instantly convinced the government to abandon laissez-faire and build a new sewer system. However, revisionist historians argue that Snow's work had very little immediate impact because the medical establishment and the General Board of Health clung obstinately to miasma theory. They suggest that the real turning point was the combination of 'The Great Stink' of 1858, which physically disrupted Parliament, and the 1867 Reform Act, which gave working-class men the vote and forced politicians to promise sanitary reforms to win elections. This culminated in the compulsory 1875 Public Health Act once Pasteur's Germ Theory finally provided the scientific proof that Snow lacked.

Q7. Explain why Edward Jenner's smallpox vaccination was significant, despite its limitations.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

Q8. Explain one way in which the role of the government in preventing disease in the period c1700-c1900 was different from the period c1500-c1700.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q9. Explain why there was rapid progress in public health in the second half of the nineteenth century (c1850-c1900).

[12 marks • 15 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- John Snow
- The Great Stink

You must also use information of your own.

General Notes

End of Unit Reflection & Pupil Voice

Unit: Paper 1: Medicine Through Time

Instructions: Now that you have completed your final assessment, take 10 minutes to reflect on your learning across this entire unit. Be honest—this is your chance to use your **Pupil Voice** to help your teacher plan future lessons.

1. What Went Well (WWW)

What topic or skill did you find most engaging or easiest to understand in this unit?

2. Even Better If (EBI)

What did you find most challenging? Are there any concepts you are still confused about?

3. Effort & Target Setting

Circle your effort level for this unit: **1 (Low)** **2** **3** **4** **5 (Excellent)**

What is one specific target you want to set for yourself in the next unit?

Teacher Feedback & Coaching

(To be completed during live marking / feedback lessons)

Factors Overview: 18th & 19th C

Edexcel focuses heavily on the factors that drove medical progress (or held it back). For each factor below, write one specific historical example from this period that either helped or hindered medical progress.

Factor	Specific Historical Example & Impact
Individuals	
The Church & Religion	
Government & Wealth	
Science & Technology	
Attitudes in Society	
War	